THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

TRANSPORT WITH CARE



Twelve bright yellow-coloured buses are doubling up as schools to educate street children in Ahmedabad

By JUMANA SHAH

Eight-year-old Anita Solanki's tryst with education began on a hot summer day last year when a bright yellow-coloured bus rolled into her poor neighbourhood in Ahmedabad. The daughter of an auto-rickshaw driver who was struggling to make ends meet, today, she attends an international school in the city. Like Anita, around 415 poor or homeless children, who had either never attended school or were forced to drop out, have been enrolled in regular schools after completing a bridge course from 12 such buses that double up as 'Signal Schools'.

Launched in March 2022 by the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) in collaboration with the Gujarat State Legal Services Authority (GSLSA), these buses pick up street children, aged between six and 14 years, around 7-8 in the morning and drop them off back in the afternoon.

SIGNAL SCHOOLS
Ahmedabad

Renovated and converted into a classroom, each bus comes equipped with a blackboard, educational toys, basic furniture, drinking water, a mini fan, an LCD television, CCTV cameras and even a WiFi connection.

But not the gadgets or the facilities, it's the warmth with which the teachers welcome them every morning that makes the children return to these buses day after day. Two teachers, hired by the civic body, are deployed on each bus. Depending on a child's age and capability, these teachers impart basic education to them for 10 months. The children are then admitted to the nearest government or grant-in-aid school.

Anita was part of the second of the three batches that have completed the bridge